

Sunset and the Seraphox

I had a dream last night. The sky was this light gray color, as hard as that is to imagine. I was walking through a wooded area, next to a pond. The fish were swimming in the water, birds were chirping, and everything was bright and cheery. The sun hung in the sky and gave everything this warm yellow tinge, and I felt bright and warm and orange, bathed in the embrace of a distant ball of flames. It was like a slice of heaven, for just a moment—and then I woke up.

In school, they teach you a lot about the past—about the way the world worked back before all this mess, and about how we got here. They don't give enough detail to picture what it was like, so we've gotta use our imaginations for some of it. Found out from a book at the library this morning that the sky was actually blue, which doesn't make any sense. If the sky is black, why would adding light make it blue? I can't tell if it's true—can't even tell if it matters. I like gray; it's a calming color, so I'm gonna keep picturing the sky like that. If I look up at the sky now, all I see is black. It's all I've known. Supposedly, somewhere up on the roof of this big ol' dome we call New York, there's a window to the sky. I've never seen it, though—if the window's there, it blends in real well. Probably just some dumb story for idiots in high school, like a pool on the roof of the school or a hallowed spot in the basement where people can't die. Kid's stuff, ya know?

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I woke up this morning same as most days. Alarm went off, I got up, threw on an old uniform, and headed out the door. I took a walk down Madison and stopped by Tim and Simon's bakery. Simon was out front and gave a friendly wave as he dragged a plastic tarp into the alley with a single hand, leaving a trail of blood behind it. As I went inside the bakery, Tim was working behind the front counter, pulling out a fresh batch of bagels. He was well over a foot

shorter than his husband, but his booming voice and boisterous personality gave him more than enough presence to compete with the soft-spoken giant of a man outside. The couple were among the few I'd consider my friends in this city. I'd been going to their bakery for years now, and they'd been there for me when my parents died. Not a lot of folks would close their shop for a while just to let a customer cry in peace—Tim and Simon did, though. When times were dark, they'd been there, and I promised to return the favor one day, somehow. Tim looked up when the front door chimed at my arrival.

“Ey, Owen. How's it goin'? You want the usual?” His voice carried effortlessly across the empty shop.

“Yeah, same as always. Simon seemed busy outside; anything to worry about?” I gestured outside as I took a seat at one of the empty tables. Tim gave a chuckle as he reached for one of the fresh bagels.

“Nah, just normal business. Some punk came in with a knife—the idiot thought we'd give him all our money over that. We refused, he attacked, Simon smashed his face in with Glenda, and I cleaned up the blood.” Glenda was the nickname they'd given to a metal pipe that had burst prior to them buying the bakery—it gave them a discount and a cheap home and made for good home defense against most of the thugs who came into the shop. “Far as I could tell, he wasn't with any of the gangs, so I'm not worried. How 'bout you? Got anything going on today? Simon and I might make a cake later, if you wanna swing by when we get off. We heard there might be some big event happening later today and figured it could be a good excuse for a cake.”

“I was gonna I'd head to the library for a bit, but then I've gotta get to work. Working the afternoon shift today, so I might not be able to make it. What's the occasion?” Tim shrugged as he brought over a plate with my bagel, along with a pair of cups: one filled with water, and the

other—“Tim, buddy. Friend. Pal. What is this?” I gave him the most sarcastic grin I could muster.

“Oh, that? I figured today’d be the day you finally tasted the finest coffee in the city and stopped being a bitch about it.” His face broke into a wide smile; the man had a lousy poker face.

“I ain’t gonna pay for the experience of a dumpster fire in my mouth, Timothy. You won’t convince me, today or any other day—not for the price you charge for that trash, anyway.” I gave him a friendly punch on the shoulder as he took the coffee for himself and took a swig.

“Fine, fine. Enjoy your bagel with your cup of *whine*—you know where to find a real drink if you change your mind. I gotta go make sure Simon is alright out there. See you tomorrow, then?” I gave him a nod as he slipped out the front door and made for the direction of his husband. Finishing my breakfast in peace, I left payment on the counter and headed out for the library.

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I’d started going to the library as a hobby back when I was a teenager. No use hanging out on the streets unless you were either trying to get mugged or doing the mugging yourself. Endless hours of entertainment and knowledge to be found at the library, and most gangs won’t touch the place. Nothing interesting for them there, and none of the nerds who frequent it are likely gonna have anything of value, so no one stakes the place out. It’s my own little safe haven, filled with a few hundred years of After writings from bored authors in the post-dome years and countless years of writing from Before.

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As I walked into the library, there was a bit of commotion at the front desk. I figured it was none of my business and moved on; I found the section of Before books and grabbed one

about clouds. Blew my mind to think that water used to just fall out of the sky like magic from, well, basically little puffs of steam in the air. All the pictures had the sky as blue, though, so I added the topic to a mental list for things to look into later. As I was getting ready to leave, one of the people who'd been at the front desk stopped at the aisle I was on. He seemed to be looking for a book intently before he noticed I was there. Before I could slip away, he called out to me with a squeaky voice, like skin on wet rubber—instantly made me wish I'd gotten out of there faster.

“Ooh, you work here, right? I'm looking for a book on planes and rocket ships and stuff, can you help me find it?” I blinked blankly at him. Several times. Then I looked down at my uniform, which clearly had the logo for the Air District emblazoned across the entire torso, and looked back up at the idiot and blinked in his direction again. He didn't seem to get the memo and turned toward the books. “Crazy times, right? The *Seraphox* came back, and I couldn't wait to find out what they've been doing all these years, so I came here. Figured I could do some research and get a jump on their big reveal, eh?”

“*Seraphox*?” That wasn't a word I was familiar with. The man actually glanced up at me for more than a second this time. “The heck is that?”

Instantly, the man seemed to straighten up. I swear his chin lifted just so he could look down on me. “Wait, did you not hear? I'm surprised a librarian wouldn't know about it—the *Seraphox* is one of them rocket ship plane thingies they sent out around the same time as the domes.” His voice had taken on a smug tone of superiority that made me want to smack him. I resisted the urge, but God, I hate when people talk down on me. “It's back! Landed just outside the dome and they're supposed to get inside later to share what they've been doing!”

At that point, his stupid voice had wiggled its way too deep into my brain, and I was done. “First, dumbass, I’m not a librarian. And second, you’re on the wrong aisle. You want space travel, two aisles that way. You’re not even in the right section, idiot.” The man looked stunned by the sudden outburst, and I saw my chance to escape. I didn’t wait for his response—I shouldered him aside and made my way out front, headed to work.

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I work at a tower in Central Park, a big block of industrial buildings in the middle of the city; the south side of the industrial park is the Air District. Two-thirds of the park is dedicated to these massive buildings. Half a dozen towers reach towards the ceiling—three of them actually connect, from what I hear. Never been far enough up one of those myself; I typically do maintenance on Tower 3 and the accompanying power plant. It’s relatively short, compared to its neighboring towers—only about two miles high. The plant around its base keeps its fans powered, which suck in air from across the city and clean it, somehow. The science goes over my head at that point. The other chunk of the industrial park is dedicated to heating and climate control—those buildings are tiny in comparison to even the smallest of the air towers. I’ve always wondered how they can keep the entire city warm from such small structures.

Elsewhere in the city, there are a few other industrial parks. Along the remnants of the rivers, there were plants that stored and purified waste and water to keep the city clean and free of thirst. Dotted around the city, there were pockets of factories manufacturing food—I don’t know what from, and frankly, I don’t think I want to know what I’m actually eating. Rumor has it that one of the parks uptown actually has a “farm” of some kind, growing food the old way, for all the rich idiots that live over there. I don’t buy it. I’ve never seen that wasn’t just scraping by, and I read a magazine article once that said most of the rich left New York once the dome was

announced. Doesn't matter to me if they're still here with, though—it's not my side of town, and I'm happy enough with the food I've got.

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As I got close to the park, the air smelled different than normal. Normally, it would be crisp and clean, with a breeze blowing from the Air District outwards. There was a heavy scent of iron in the air, however—a smell that didn't belong. The smell of blood. I began to look around for a source. Down an alleyway, I caught a glimpse of movement; as I approached, the ground inside was slick and dark with crimson streaks. Buried in a pile of trash bags, I could see pieces of a body sticking out—two arms, a leg—no, three arms and a leg. None of the arms seemed to match, though. I could feel my stomach twist into a knot. Someone had killed at least three people here, and they hadn't been clean kills—there was blood everywhere, splattered along the walls, across dumpsters, leaking out from under various piles of trash. It was like they'd been ripped apart.

Throughout my life, I'd seen my fair share of violence and death, but this was sickening. This wasn't a fight that got out of hand or a kill to prove a point. Someone enjoyed this. On the front of a newspaper, drawn in blood, was a simple smiling face—just a circle with two dots for eyes and a crescent for a mouth. As I looked at it, I heard something running at me from deeper in the alley. My eyes shot up at the same time as my arms to protect myself, and I caught whatever was running at me with a blow to the face. It stumbled backwards, and I could finally see it was a person.

He couldn't have been more than 20 years old, but his face was covered in blood and his eyes spoke of madness. He grasped his face in surprise where my fist had connected—and that's when I noticed his hands. Along the tips of his fingers, the flesh had been cleaved from bone,

now sharpened into claws. They, too, were covered in blood—not his own, I suspected. He let out an inhuman shriek and rushed at me, bone claws reaching for my throat. Whatever this creature had been, it seemed too far gone to be considered human to me. Lunging with the reckless desperation of a cornered animal, it exposed itself for a moment. Seizing the opportunity, I dodged its strike and launched one of my own, aiming for its throat; my fist connected with its chin instead. Its head flew back with a sudden crack resounding in the air before it crumpled to the ground, unmoving.

I stood my ground, ready for it to leap back into action, but nothing happened. I reached out a wary foot and kicked the creature to no response, still not believing it could be dead. It felt... too sudden. Too easy. For that blow to kill it, it would have to be fragile- way more fragile than any human I'd fought before. Could it have actually been a human, or just some monster posing as one?

As I caught my breath and the adrenaline slowly died down, the knot in my stomach began to churn. I stumbled over to a dumpster as my breakfast made a return trip. Feeling slightly less sick, I began to kick around the trash in the alley. From what I could tell, there were only three victims—not including the monster. I didn't recognize anyone from the remains, but there are a lot of people in New York. As for the monster, I had no clue where it had crawled out from. Most people I knew fell into one of three groups: victims, groupies, and independents; these weren't official groups, just something I'd noticed. Victims didn't survive in New York. Everyone got into a potentially deadly fight or got mugged at some point, and victims usually reacted with running away or pleading, neither of which helped them survive for long—it's probably what got these three killed. Most people either found safety in numbers—joining gangs, making alliances, whatever it takes—or training to be able to handle any fight that came their

way. This monster didn't act like any of them, like any human I'd seen in New York. It was like the animals in stories I'd read, feral and wild and unrefined. I wanted to know what it was; I could feel the curiosity burning inside me. I brushed myself off and walked out of the alleyway; I wouldn't find answers there. City Hall seemed like the place to go; although they don't do much in terms of governing this city, they do keep a record of all the living citizens for census purposes. If there had been a bunch of killings, someone there might know. Plus, I'm supposed to report any deaths I find, anyway. It would at least give me an excuse to be late to work in my search for answers.

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When I got to City Hall, it seemed as empty as the last time I'd come. About six years back, I'd come back home from the library and found the apartment too quiet. My parents were always full of life and would run to the door when they heard it open, so the silence was deafening. I walked into the living room to find the two of them curled up together in a puddle of blood, each with a knife in their backs. According to a neighbor, they must have pissed off a gang somehow, because several of them showed up all at once and forced their way inside when my parents answered the door. If I'd been there, I'd probably have died too. After the shock and pain had begun to wear off, I'd gone on the long walk to City Hall. Just like back then, the Hall today had only a few tired employees and maybe half a dozen visitors. I walked up to the front desk, was handed a cold sheet of paper to fill out, and was waved away without so much as a word. I filled it out, leaving the location of the alleyway where I'd fought the monster and number of individuals. Sitting in the silence, filling out line after line of paperwork, reducing people's lives to just boxes on a form—although I keep myself pretty distanced from most people, it still made me feel hollow inside. Or, maybe it was just remembering my parents and

filling this same paperwork out for them; either way, I was getting uncomfortable. I quickly finished the rest of the sheet and handed it to the lady at the counter.

Before I left, I asked around those that were there if they'd heard about a monster sighting or a serial killer or anything. Unfortunately, no one who responded had any real answers, not even the employees. A couple people thought I was crazy or on drugs. Some threw out their theories, though—one lady said it must have crawled out of the sewers, driven crazy by years of solitude. One guy said it had to come from the *Seraphox*- no way could it be from in New York. This other guy swore he had a cousin who knew a guy whose brother's roommate worked on patching a hole in the dome years ago, so it must be some mutant human adapted to life outside the dome who found a crack to slip inside. I dismissed his idea immediately—nothing survives outside. That's why we have the dome.

A few hundred years back, scientists noticed the Sun was losing its heat. It seemed impossible, but the world united to prepare for the worst, just in case. Scientists across the globe cooperated in an era where technology progressed in leaps and bounds to ensure survival. Domes were constructed around the largest cities in the world to trap in heat and resources, food synthesis and material recycling progressed to such an efficient level as to be sustainable for hundreds and hundreds of years, and—as I found out earlier today—space travel progressed to the point where massive ships were sent out. Eventually, the sun did set—forever. It didn't explode like many thought it would; it just... burned itself out. Like a candle, burned to cinders, until nothing was left. For hundreds of years, life under the dome of New York has been dark and bleak and isolated.

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After talking to the people at City Hall and finding no real answers, I realized I was pretty late for work. I hurried off to Tower 3, thinking all the while. When I got to work, I tried to shut my brain down and focus on the job, but I couldn't. The image of that creature just kept popping up. What was it? Where did it come from? And, most importantly, was it alone? If it was a one-time incident, it wasn't too bad, but what if there were more? The more I tried to force the curiosity away, the more questions burned into the front of my mind. The only place I could think of finding answers was the *Seraphox*. The creature couldn't have come from outside, but surely, if it were from within New York, someone would have heard a story about it, or something similar. No one I'd talked to had. The only other option was that mysterious ship the guy at the library mentioned. If that was the culprit though, someone would find out later, when the crew comes inside to talk, right? But what if they were? What if they unleash something into the city? What if it ends up getting to Tim and Simon? I choked up at this thought; the possibility that they could end up like those victims—no, those people in the alleyway... Not if I could do something about it. I vowed to investigate further after I got off work. If something was wrong, I'd figure it out. I'd find my answers.

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After work, I asked around. Eventually, I found a guy who'd once done maintenance on a gate to the east. According to him, there was a smaller dome attached to the other side of two gates; that dome could open up and allow for ships in and out, but it sealed tightly enough that New York could, with a bit of time, "equalize pressure and provide air" or something. I wasn't quite sure what he meant by that, but what it boiled down to was I had a lead on where the *Seraphox* might be docked. It took almost an hour to get to the area where the guy said the gate was; I actually passed both the bakery and my apartment on the way there, although I ended up

going further east than I'd ever gone before. I'd never seen a gate in the dome; I didn't even know they existed, but I guess it makes sense to have some way in or out. As I approached the wall, I felt a sense of awe; the gate itself was massive, probably two hundred feet tall. There was no way I could get that open. As I got closer, though, I noticed a much smaller door to the side. This one was closer to the size of a hallway; if I had to guess, it was for transporting people, while the big door was for cargo of some kind. I took a quick glance around the area. No one seemed to be around; the area itself just seemed to be used for storage, with a few warehouses and countless crates scattered around. Since I was alone, I approached the smaller door. It had no apparent handle; I could tell by the two-inch gap, however, that it slid open—that someone had slid it open. I tensed up; something wasn't right. I raised my fists into a defensive position and moved towards the door. Peering inside, nothing seemed wrong. It was a brightly lit hallway with another sliding door at the other end, but that was it. The other door seemed to still be closed, from what I could tell. I pried the door open the rest of the way, then slipped inside.

As I neared the other end of the hallway, I began to inspect the door. As I stared, I realized there was a small indentation on the door to serve as a grip, in case of emergencies. I reached for it, then pulled my hand back. What if there was something waiting on the other side? The monster from earlier flashed through my mind; I didn't want to be caught off guard. Pressing my face into the door, I listened intently. On the other side of the door, I could hear nothing. The silence was deafening. I carefully grasped the door and slid it open; it took all my strength to do so. Inside, the dome was dark. I could see the vague outline of the *Seraphox*; it was massive. When the man had said that this was a smaller dome, I had pictured something small; from what I could tell in the darkness, though, the *Seraphox* was almost a third of the size of our city, and it fit rather comfortably in here. As I gazed in awe, my guard dropped for a

moment, and that's when I heard something. Coming from a pile of crates, maybe 50 feet from the gate I'd entered from, I heard a small clatter as something fell over. I whipped around, fists raised, and could make out the shape of a person. They quickly ducked back behind the crates, but I could hear them swearing under their breath. It didn't seem like a monster, so I approached, keeping my guard up just in case. As I came around the crates, I saw a man; he immediately curled into a ball on the floor and raised his hands, like that would ward me off. I rolled my eyes, then called out to him.

"Hey. You, on the floor. What are you doing?" The man immediately glanced up. He shot up off the ground, grabbed me by the shoulder, and pulled me into a crouch—a feat his shorter frame seemed to have difficulty with.

"Quiet, or they'll hear! It's not safe here, you have to get me out!" As the stranger spoke, his eyes were constantly darting around, head on a swivel. Something had him spooked.

"Why? What's the danger? Is it the monsters?" I responded in a hushed voice. The man's fidgety gaze transfixed on me.

"If that's what you want to call them, yes. You've seen them, then? And you survived?" As I began to respond, his hand shot up to my mouth and his eyes opened wide with fear. He motioned for me to be quiet with his other hand. In the sudden silence, I could hear footsteps nearby. I slowly glanced back towards the door. Outlined in the light of the door I had opened, I watched in horror as around a dozen monsters, similar in appearance to the one I'd fought earlier, shambled eerily into the hall. I started forward without thinking, but the man grabbed my arm and pulled me back. Even in the dim light, as I looked at him, I could see the fear in his eyes. He motioned for me to wait, and I did. He might have answers, and I couldn't handle all those things at once. After a few more moments, the man began to speak in a hushed whisper.

“If you’ve seen one of them before, you know they can’t be reasoned with. We should give them a moment to clear out, then slip out while we still can. That is only a scouting party, there are many more in the ship.” The stranger sighed and shook his head. “They had all been trapped in here until you came in, and now, they’ll all get out, if you don’t close that door. There was a woman who came in earlier to look around; while she was distracted, I saw one of the... monsters, as you called them, slip out. A few others saw the light and came running, the woman panicked, and she ran, slamming the door shut behind her. Since then, I’ve been hiding as close as I could to the exit in case someone came back.”

I took a glance around. In the distance, approaching from the *Seraphox*, I could see a vague group of shadows already. I looked at the shorter man beside me.

“It’s now or never. I’m going for the door, before that group gets here. If they haven’t cleared out the other side, I’ll fight my way out, but if that door is the only thing keeping them here, then I’m closing that door. Come with me or stay, it’s your choice.” In response, the stranger simply gave a nod. The two of us broke into a dead sprint for the gate. In the distance, I could hear an inhuman screech, followed by a stampede of footsteps. In just a few moments, we had reached the gate. We slipped inside, and the two of us shoved the door shut with all our might. Glancing around and seeing the hallway empty, the stranger crashed to his knees, chest heaving as he struggled to catch his breath.

After a couple minutes, I helped the man up from the ground. We snuck out from the hallway, glancing every direction at every turn, but the monsters were nowhere to be found. I closed the second gate, just in case, and began to drag crates over to block the door. The man, who introduced himself as Marth, didn’t do much to help, although he did give me some of the answers I was seeking.

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Marth was a crew member on the *Seraphox*. He, like many generations before him, had grown up there. Throughout those generations, life was peaceful and happy—a utopia among the stars, searching for a new planet for humanity to call home. Over the generations, the children grew smaller and less active—whether the cause was a lifestyle or something in the food or even just genetics, no one knew, and no one really cared. However, there was a sick child in this latest generation; a teenage boy named Seth came down with some kind of space madness. There had been the occasional case of it before, but Seth was far worse than had been seen. He murdered his mother; he just started clawing at her suddenly. Most of those on the *Seraphox* were fragile, and so, even as his family pulled Seth away, his mother’s fate was already sealed. Marth lived down the hall at that time, and as a pair of guards dragged Seth to the brig, Marth could hear him muttering under his breath, a single word, over and over. “Freedom.”

Marth wasn’t the only one who heard Seth. Unfortunately, some of the others living on the ship had begun to feel cramped—like the walls were closing in and the halls were too crowded. Seth’s brutal act of murder acted as a catalyst, pushing others to the brink of madness, and then some. Eventually, it manifested into a cult of people who wanted to make more space, to throw off the shackles of morality, or to just be like Seth. They stormed the brig and freed Seth, who had, by then, gone so mad he had begun peeling the skin from his bones. His followers believed he was enlightened, and began to follow in his footsteps. As they all grew more and more depraved, it wasn’t enough to mutilate themselves. They began to hunt and kill the other passengers for sport, until eventually, they seized the ship. It was then that the cult learned the *Seraphox* had been unsuccessful in its mission and was returning to Earth. The cult recruited those who would join and confined everyone else. Most of the cult was of a younger generation

and did not know how to run the ship, so they kept those alive who could and used their families to coerce them. Once they landed successfully in New York, everyone was released into the ship, where they were hunted down and slaughtered. As far as Marth knew, he was the sole survivor of the hunt.

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As Marth finished telling his story, I moved the last crate into position. I glanced at the man; in the dim lighting here at the edge of the dome, he looked even smaller than I had thought. I could tell he wasn't lying, but something told me there might be more to the story. I didn't care enough to push further.

"You said everyone on the *Seraphox* was smaller and weaker, right? So there's no way they're getting through all of this?" I gestured towards the mountain of crates I'd stacked up against the door. Marth nodded his head and opened his mouth to speak, but I cut him off. "Alright, that's that then. Welcome to New York. If you need anything, you can find me most mornings at—Shit!" I'd gotten so caught up in Marth's story, I'd forgotten about the monsters that slipped into the city. I wasn't worried about most of the monsters; most of us in the city could easily handle a fight with one. There were two people I was worried about, though—a pair of bakers, not too far from the gate, who would probably be asleep at this hour. I didn't care if the odds were low, I had to make sure they were safe. I broke into a dead sprint, running towards the bakery.

As I made my way through the streets, I could hear the occasional sound of fighting and even caught a glimpse of one of the monsters being teamed up on by a trio of gang members. It gave me hope that, maybe, none of the monsters would have made it that far. As I rounded the corner and laid eyes on the bakery, my fear quickened my pace. Ahead, there was a monster, skulking around near the bakery, bone claws at the ready to strike. As I closed in, ready to pounce, a resounding clang stopped me in my tracks. The monster had leapt into the bakery, only to be met with a sturdy metal pipe to the face. Emerging from the bakery, the hulking form of Simon stood over the crumpled figure that would haunt my nightmares. He gave a look around the street. When he saw me, wheezing as I tried to catch my breath, he gave a friendly wave.

“Hi, Owen! We’ve still got some cake, if you want it! I figure that’s why you’re comin’ by, eh?” The sudden absurdity of the situation got to me in that moment. Cake. Of all things, that’s what was on their minds. I broke into uncontrolled laughter. Here I’d been, worried that my curiosity had killed the two closest friends I had, and they were eating cake. I didn’t even need to protect them; they could do that on their own. As my laughter began to subside, I decided to take him up on his offer. Maybe I couldn’t protect them, but I could at least be a friend. As we walked inside, Tim was sitting at the counter, drinking a cup of coffee, and damn, I had just the story to liven things up.